

RESOLVE MUN 2026

Disarmament and International Security Committee

*Discussion on regulating Anti-Satellite Weapons,
Offensive Counter-Space capabilities and Dual-Use
Space Technologies within the Framework of
Preventing an Arms Race in Outer Space (PAROS).*

Letter from the Executive Board

Dear Delegates,

We are very pleased to welcome you to the simulation of the *UNGA: DISEC at Resolve MUN 2026*. It is an honour to serve as your Executive Board for the duration of the conference. This Background Guide is designed to give you an insight into the case at hand, so we hope this acts as only a catalyst for furthering your research and not limited to just this guide. Please refer to it carefully. Remember, a thorough understanding of the problem is the first step to solving it.

Do understand that this Background Guide is in no way exhaustive and is only meant to provide you with enough background information to establish a platform for beginning the research. Delegates are highly recommended to do a good amount of research beyond what is covered in the Guide. The guide cannot be used as proof during the committee proceedings under any circumstances.

We understand that MUN conferences can be an overwhelming experience for first-timers but it must be noted that our aspirations from the delegates are not how experienced or articulate they are. Rather, we want to see how one manages the balance to respect disparities and differences of opinion and work around this while extending their foreign policy to present comprehensive solutions without compromising on their self-interests and initiate consensus building.

New ideas are by their very nature disruptive, but far less disruptive than a world set against the backdrop of stereotypes and regional instability due to which reform is essential in policy making and conflict resolution. At any point during your research, do not hesitate to contact the Executive Board Members for clarifications or in case you need help in any other aspect. We look forward to a fruitful discussion and an enriching experience with all of you.

Best regards,

Eswar Chava

Chairperson

Raunaq Sinha

Vice Chairperson

Vansh Rajwani

Rapporteur

Important Points to Remember

A few aspects that delegates should keep in mind while preparing:

1. **Procedure:** The purpose of putting in procedural rules in any committee is to ensure a more organized and efficient debate. The committee will follow the UNA-USA Rules of Procedure. Although the Executive Board shall be fairly strict with the Rules of Procedure, the discussion of the agenda will be the main priority. So, delegates are advised not to restrict their statements due to hesitation regarding procedure.
2. **Foreign Policy:** Following the foreign policy of one's country is the most important aspect of a Model UN Conference. This is what essentially differentiates a Model UN from other debating formats. To violate one's foreign policy without adequate reason is one of the worst mistakes a delegate can make.
3. **Role of the Executive Board:** The Executive Board is appointed to facilitate debate. The committee shall decide the direction and flow of debate. The delegates are the ones who constitute the committee and hence must be uninhibited while presenting their opinions/stance on any issue. However, the Executive Board may put forward questions and/or ask for clarifications at all points of time to further debate and test participants.
4. **Nature of Source/Evidence:** This Background Guide is meant solely for research purposes and must not be cited as evidence to substantiate statements made during the conference. Evidence or proof for substantiating statements made during formal debate is acceptable from the following sources:
 - a. **United Nations:** Documents and findings by the United Nations or any related UN body is held as a credible proof to support a claim or argument. Multilateral Organizations: Documents from international organizations like OIC, NATO, SAARC, BRICS, EU, ASEAN, the International Court of Justice, etc. may also be presented as credible sources of information.
 - b. **Government Reports:** These reports can be used in a similar way as the State Operated News Agencies reports and can, in all circumstances, be denied by another country.
 - c. **News Sources:**
 1. Reuters: Any Reuters article that clearly makes mention of the fact or is in contradiction of the fact being stated by a delegate in council.

2. State operated News Agencies: These reports can be used in the support of or against the State that owns the News Agency. These reports, if credible or substantial enough, can be used in support of or against any country as such but in that situation, may be denied by any other country in the council. Some examples are – RIA Novosti (Russian Federation), Xinhua News Agency (People’s Republic of China), etc.

****Please Note: Reports from NGOs working with UNESCO, UNICEF and other UN bodies will be accepted. Under no circumstances will sources like Wikipedia, or newspapers like the Guardian, Times of India, etc. be accepted. However, notwithstanding the criteria for acceptance of sources and evidence, delegates are still free to quote/cite from any source as they deem fit as a part of their statements.*

Guidelines

- Read the entirety of the background guide in the order it was written. Make sure to highlight the names of specific treaties, documents, resolutions, conventions, international bodies, events and any other specific incidents so that you can get back to them later and do a lot more thorough research.
- Understand some of the basic details regarding the country that you've been allotted whether this be the capital, current affairs regarding geopolitical situation, political hierarchy etc. While not strictly necessary, you never know when this can turn out to be handy. Geography Now's A - Z Country List has been a particularly helpful resource for this.
- Use a search engine of your choice to create as many tabs as possible for the highlighted terms from your background guide. Wikipedia or a YouTube video act as a great way to get a brief summary of the incidents at hand but such sources (especially Wikipedia articles) cannot be used in committee as sources.
- Delve into deeper research regarding the particular position of your allocation with the agenda at hand. Try searching for the voting stances of your allocation in related conventions and understanding the reasons for voting as so. UN Press Releases are also a helpful source for this matter.
- Find the website for the foreign ministry of the country you have been assigned alongside the "Permanent Mission of COUNTRY to the United Nations" website and search for a key term relating to the agenda, this should often give you statements from recent press conferences or UN committee sessions that can act as valuable sources of information in forming a position.
- Keep a handy copy of the Charter of the United Nations, whether as a .pdf file extension or a physical copy works. This contains the founding principles of the United Nations and contains articles that lay out the mandate of the six bodies that the United Nations is primarily divided into. Spend some additional time researching the specific mandate and functions of the committee that you have been assigned.
- The Executive Board may ask for the source of a statement that a delegate makes in committee either during a Point of Order circumstance or if said statement stands to be of interest to the Executive Board. Therefore, it is recommended that delegates keep track of their sources when making / disputing a claim and also ensure their validity.

Please do remember that while you as a delegate are allowed to cite any source you wish during committee.

Hierarchy of evidence

Evidence can be presented from a wide variety of sources, but not all sources are treated as equal. Here's the hierarchy in which evidence is categorised:

Tier 1: Includes any publication, statement, resolution, or document released by any of the Nations' official organs or committees; any publication, statement, or document released by a UN member state in its own capacity. The evidence falling in this tier is considered most reliable during the simulation.

Tier 2: Includes: any news article published by any official media source that is owned and controlled by a UN member state. E.g.: Xinhua News (China), Prasar Bharti (India), BBC (United Kingdom) etcetera. The evidence falling in this tier is considered sufficiently reliable in case no other evidence from any Tier 1 source is available on that particular fact, event, or situation.

Tier 3: Includes: any publication from news sources of international repute such as Reuters, The New York Times, Agence-France Presse, etcetera. The evidence falling under this tier is considered the least reliable for the purposes of this simulation. Yet, if no better source is available in a certain scenario, it may be considered.

Foreign Policy and Foreign Relations

Foreign policy, in simple terms, is what your country aims to achieve in regard to the issue at hand or in general with its relations with other countries.

1. What role must foreign policy play in your research?

Understanding the foreign policy of your country must be a checkbox that you tick off at the very beginning of your research.

Your foreign policy should dictate everything from the arguments you make, the reasoning you give for making those arguments, and the actions you take in the Council.

2. Where do I look to find foreign policy?

Most of the time, foreign policy is not explicitly stated. It must be inferred from the actions and statements issued by the country. Reading the meeting records from previous meetings of UNSC (or any other UN body where your country might have spoken on the issue) is a great place to start. If such records are unavailable, look for statements from your country's Foreign Ministry (or equivalent like Ministry of External Affairs, Ministry for Foreign Affairs etcetera) and top leadership (PM, Pres., Secretary of State, Defence Minister).

Foreign Relations on the other hand refers to the diplomatic ties that one country has with another and considers elements such as the mutual presence of embassies, consulates, ambassadors & diplomatic dialogue. More often than not, foreign policy is what will be of your primary concern during the MUN, but it is important to also consider any extremities in your allotted country's foreign relations.

Introduction to Agenda

The outer space domain, historically conceptualized as a vast global common dedicated to the peaceful exploration, scientific advancement, and shared heritage of humanity, has undergone a radical and perilous transformation. In the contemporary geopolitical landscape, outer space has evolved into a highly congested, contested, and competitive strategic theatre. The rapid proliferation of advanced space technologies, coupled with an exponentially increasing global reliance on satellite infrastructure for critical civilian, economic, and military operations, has fundamentally altered the geopolitical calculus surrounding space security. This profound operational reliance across all sectors of modern society exposes a critical strategic vulnerability: the potential disruption, degradation, or outright destruction of space-based assets. Such hostile actions could precipitate catastrophic cascading effects across global telecommunications networks, financial routing systems, emergency response and disaster management mechanisms, and the strategic military command-and-control architectures of spacefaring nations. The stakes of space security have thus transcended the abstract realms of astrophysics, positioning themselves at the very epicentre of terrestrial national security and global macroeconomic stability.

The emergence and operational deployment of Anti-Satellite (ASAT) weapons, sophisticated offensive counter-space capabilities, and the inherent, pervasive ambiguity of dual-use space technologies have dramatically accelerated the militarization and potential weaponization of the outer space environment. Nations are increasingly viewing space not merely as a benign vacuum for scientific inquiry, but as a critical warfighting domain where terrestrial geopolitical rivalries are actively extended. This paradigm shift has led to an arms dynamic wherein the development of offensive capabilities by one state inevitably triggers corresponding defensive and offensive developments by strategic rivals, risking a rapid and uncontrollable escalation. In response to these escalating multidimensional threats, the

international community, operating primarily through the United Nations disarmament machinery and specifically the Disarmament and International Security Committee (DISEC), has urgently sought to establish robust regulatory frameworks, legally binding treaties, and universally accepted behavioural norms.

At the absolute centre of these multilateral diplomatic efforts is the Prevention of an Arms Race in Outer Space (PAROS) framework. The negotiation, codification, and implementation of legally binding instruments, alongside practical transparency and confidence-building measures within the PAROS agenda, represent a critical and immediate imperative. The objective is to ensure the long-term sustainability, security, and peaceful use of the outer space environment before the threshold of weaponization is irreversibly crossed. To navigate this complex diplomatic challenge, delegates must grapple with the physical realities of orbital mechanics, the limitations of half-century-old international space law, and the rapid pace of technological innovation that continually outstrips the international community's ability to regulate it. The present analysis provides an exhaustive, multi-layered examination of the historical trajectory, legal dimensions, technological parameters, and geopolitical dynamics characterizing the regulation of space weapons and counter-space technologies under the auspices of the PAROS framework.

Mandate of DISEC

The Disarmament and International Security Committee (DISEC), also known as the First Committee of the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA), is tasked with addressing issues that lie at the core of global stability such as peace, security, and disarmament. Formed in 1946, DISEC operates under Articles 11 and 26 of the Charter of the United Nations, granting it authority to deliberate on and recommend measures related to disarmament and the maintenance of international peace and security.

Unlike the Security Council, DISEC lacks enforcement powers. Its resolutions are recommendatory rather than binding, reflecting the democratic ethos of the General Assembly, where every Member State holds an equal voice in shaping global security discourse. The Committee serves as a forum for multilateral negotiation, bridging the divide between enforcement and deliberation through collective decision-making and political will.

The Seven Avenues of DISEC's Deliberation

The scope of DISEC's discussions is traditionally organized around seven thematic avenues, which together define the breadth of its mandate:

1. **General Principles of Disarmament** – Framing global and regional efforts to reduce or eliminate weapons systems.
2. **Regulation of Armaments** – Designing mechanisms for transparency, verification, and restraint in the acquisition or deployment of arms.
3. **International Security Questions** – Evaluating broader security concerns that may destabilize the international order.
4. **Peaceful Settlement of Disputes** – Promoting mediation, dialogue, and preventive diplomacy as alternatives to force.

5. **Regional Disarmament and Cooperation** – Encouraging collective defence, confidence-building measures, and region-specific arms control.
6. **Prevention of the Arms Race** – Addressing technological and strategic competition in weapon development.
7. **Scientific and Technological Developments** – Assessing emerging technologies and their implications for warfare, deterrence, and peacekeeping.

Each of these avenues defines DISEC's operational mandate and provides Member States with procedural guidance on the scope of debate.

Key Concepts and Definitions

Before any meaningful discussion on the agenda takes place, you must be aware of the foundational concepts and contested definitions within the agenda's scope. Please note that some of the terms listed below do not have universally agreed or codified definitions and a lot of them depend upon a state's interpretation of the said term.

Prevention of an Arms Race in Outer Space (PAROS)

It refers to a normative objective as well as a specific institutional process ongoing within the United Nations system. As an objective, PAROS refers to the international community's collective goal of ensuring that the outer space is not weaponized and turned into an arena of armed competition, weapons deployment and active conflict. As an institutional process within the UN, PAROS has been a standing agenda item in the UN General Assembly since 1981 and has been discussed in the Conference of Disarmament (CD) continuously since 1982 and has since become item 7 of the CD's formal agenda. Although no formal treaty has been successfully negotiated which governs the various aspects of space disarmament, the UNGA has adopted various resolutions under the title PAROS calling upon member states to refrain from actions which contradict the peaceful uses of outer space, these resolutions remain solely as political declaration rather than legally binding. Therefore, PAROS is best understood as a framework and aspiration rather than a concluded treaty.

Outer Space

A basic term like this itself lacks a universally agreed definition in international law. While the Outer Space Treaty of 1967 (OST) governs activities "in outer space" it does not specify where the airspace ends and outer space begins. A lot of states have commonly accepted it to be 100 kilometers above sea level, but it does not have any formal legal status. The absence of a defined boundary has implications for the application of any future arms control regime.

Militarization Of Outer Space

It refers to any use of the outer space for military purposes. In accordance to this definition the outer space has already been militarized in the sense that reconnaissance satellites, communication satellites, navigation systems like GPS already serve for militaries.

Militarization does not necessarily equate to presence of weapons. The distinction between militarization and weaponization is crucial for the PAROS debate as militarization has now become a de facto reality, the main contested question surrounds the weaponization and whether it should be permitted or prohibited.

Weaponization Of Outer Space

refers specifically to the introduction of weapons into the space environment, whether space-based weapons designed to strike targets in space or on Earth, or ground-based weapons designed to target space objects. China has used the term de-weaponization to mean the banning of the development, testing, production, deployment, and use of any space weapons and the destruction of all existing ones. Importantly, the term weaponization has been interpreted differently by various delegations at the CD, with some arguing it encompasses all military satellites and others restricting it strictly to weapons as such.

Anti Satellite Weapons (ASAT'S)

A technology or a system which has been designed to destroy, damage or degrade a satellite or its functionalities, whether through a kinetic collision or a non-kinetic interference. They broadly fall into two categories: projectiles which utilize kinetic energy and destroy satellites through a physical collision (KE-ASATS). They include direct-ascent missiles launched from the ground or aircraft, as well as co-orbital systems that rendezvous with a target satellite before detonating, and non-kinetic ASATs, which encompass directed energy weapons such as high-power lasers, electronic warfare tools such as jamming, cyber-attacks against satellite

command and control systems, and radio frequency interference. The definitional challenge is that any technology capable of damaging a satellite qualifies as an ASAT under a broad reading, making the category extraordinarily difficult to regulate in a treaty.

Offensive Counter-Space Capabilities

A broader term that encompasses all capabilities, technologies, and operations intended to deny, degrade, disrupt, deceive, or destroy an adversary's space systems and services \.

Counter-space capabilities include ASATs but go beyond them to include electronic warfare against satellite communications, cyber operations against ground control stations, directed energy attacks, and co-orbital operations involving satellites that can manoeuvre close to adversary spacecraft. The distinction between defensive counter-space (protecting one's own assets) and offensive counter-space (attacking adversary assets) is strategically and legally significant but practically difficult to establish from outside observation.

Dual-Use Space Technologies

refers to technologies, systems, or capabilities that have both legitimate civilian or scientific purposes and potential military or offensive applications. In the space domain, this problem is uniquely pervasive: a satellite equipped to receive signals can use the same antenna to jam neighbouring satellites; active debris removal technology designed to clean up orbital debris can equally be used to seize or destroy active satellites; rendezvous and proximity operations conducted for spacecraft servicing purposes employ the same skill set required for a co-orbital ASAT weapon. The dual-use character of space technologies is one of the most formidable obstacles to any arms control regime because a meaningful treaty must differentiate between permitted and prohibited uses of the same underlying technology.

History

The history of the PAROS agenda is defined by decades of multilateral efforts to prevent the weaponization of space, which have consistently been undermined by the strategic competition of major spacefaring powers. The initiative formally began at the 1978 UN General Assembly and gained momentum with a 1981 Soviet draft treaty, which placed PAROS firmly on the UN Conference on Disarmament's agenda.

Between 1985 and 1994, dedicated Ad Hoc Committees attempted to address space security and confidence-building measures but were paralyzed by fundamental disagreements. Non-aligned and Eastern bloc states pushed for a mandate to negotiate a legally binding treaty, while Western nations, led by the United States, insisted on limiting the scope to non-binding discussions, arguing that a multilateral space weapons ban could not be effectively verified. This deadlock caused the committees to collapse after 1994, plunging the Conference on Disarmament into a multi-decade stalemate.

In the prolonged absence of a comprehensive international treaty prohibiting conventional space weapons, several advanced nations unilaterally developed and live-tested destructive kinetic anti-satellite (ASAT) weapons. These actions have fundamentally altered the orbital environment, generating hazardous, long-lasting space debris that acts as a persistent threat to all commercial, civil, and military space operations.

Previous Instances of ASAT Tests

The first ASAT Tests were conducted at the peak of the cold war. Some of the instances are:

1. United States of America

The United States executed the Solwind test in September 1985, utilizing an air-launched ASM-135 missile fired from an F-15 fighter jet to destroy a functioning US

scientific satellite (P78-1 Solwind), an event that generated significant amounts of trackable orbital debris.

2. People's Republic of China

On January 11, 2007, the People's Republic of China conducted a highly successful direct-ascent ASAT test against its own aging Fengyun-1C meteorological satellite.

Occurring at an altitude of approximately 865 kilometres, this kinetic impact resulted in the catastrophic fragmentation of the satellite, creating an expanding cloud of over 3,000 pieces of trackable debris and tens of thousands of lethal, untraceable micro-fragments. This test was widely condemned by the international community as one of the most severe and irresponsible anthropogenic debris-generating events in history, significantly elevating the baseline risk for all subsequent space operations.

3. Republic of India

In March 2019, the Republic of India joined the exclusive ranks of states possessing proven kinetic ASAT capabilities by executing "Mission Shakti." In this test, India destroyed one of its own Microsat-R satellites in low Earth orbit. However, India explicitly noted that the test was conducted at a highly depressed altitude (approximately 300 kilometres) specifically chosen to ensure the rapid atmospheric re-entry and orbital decay of the resulting fragments, attempting to minimize long-term environmental degradation.

The diplomatic response to the enduring stagnation of the Conference on Disarmament and the severe environmental reality of continued kinetic testing has manifested through parallel, often competing initiatives within the United Nations General Assembly. In 2008, and subsequently updated in 2014, the Russian Federation and China introduced the draft Treaty on the Prevention of the Placement of Weapons in Outer Space, the Threat or Use of Force against Outer Space Objects (PPWT) to the Conference on Disarmament, aggressively

advocating for a legally binding prohibition. Conversely, Western states have increasingly prioritized the establishment of non-legally binding norms of responsible behaviour.

In response to growing concerns and the failure of the PPWT process, the United Kingdom introduced UNGA Resolution 75/36 in 2020, entitled "Reducing Space Threats through

Norms, Rules and Principles of Responsible

Behaviours," which created a new

diplomatic track focused on voluntary

norms rather than legally binding treaty

obligations. Building on this, in April 2022

the United States announced a unilateral

moratorium on the testing of destructive

kinetic direct-ascent anti-satellite weapons, connecting this to its advocacy for voluntary

norms at the OEWG and beyond. Australia, Canada, Germany, Japan, New Zealand, South

Korea, Switzerland, and the United Kingdom have subsequently endorsed self-imposed bans

of a similar nature. The UNGA also established an Open-Ended Working Group (OEWG) on

Reducing Space Threats, which held four sessions in 2022-2023 with over 70 participating

countries and dozens of civil society observers, making it one of the most inclusive space

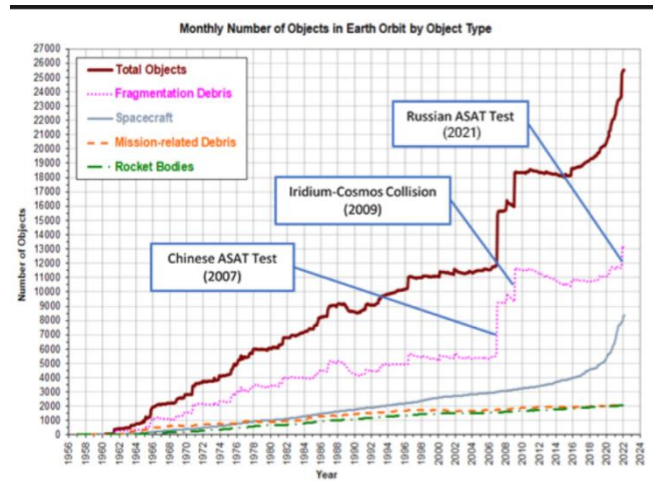
security dialogues in history. Despite this broad participation, the OEWG failed to deliver a

consensus final report, primarily due to resistance from Russia and China, though it produced

substantial groundwork for future space security governance. As of 2025, a new OEWG on

PAROS has been convened, representing the latest iteration of the longstanding multilateral

effort to address this challenge.



Existing Legal Framework

The existing legal frameworks which govern space security have good intentions but in today's age they have been acknowledged to be outdated, fragmented and riddled with critical gaps. These were constructed in an era during which the world had only two major superpowers which had meaningful space capabilities and before the rise of ASAT systems, directed energy weapons, cyber capabilities. In the current era even non-state actors might have the capacity to penetrate into a satellite's critical system and compromise them.

1. Outer Space Treaty 1967 (OST)

It provides the cornerstone of international space law. Article IV of the OST prohibits states from placing nuclear weapons or any other weapons of mass destruction in Earth orbit, on celestial bodies, or anywhere else in outer space, and bans all types of weapons on celestial bodies. However, the OST crucially does not prohibit conventional weapons in orbit, non-nuclear ASAT systems, or the use of space to support military operations on Earth. The concept of "peaceful purposes" in the OST is contested and circumvented, especially in the context of dual-use technologies, because many states interpret it to permit military support functions that do not directly involve weapons in space. The OST is also decades old and does not address the technical realities of modern space weapons, including cyber-attacks, directed energy, or co-orbital ASATs.

2. Partial Test Ban Treaty 1963

It prohibits nuclear weapons tests in the atmosphere, in outer space, and under water. This effectively prohibits the use and deployment of nuclear-tipped ASAT weapons in space and represents a meaningful but narrow constraint. It is worth noting, however, that China and Iran are not parties to the PTBT, limiting its universality.

3. **Anti-Ballistic Missile Treaty**

It concluded bilaterally between the United States and Soviet Union in 1972, restricted the deployment of missile defence systems and was widely credited with maintaining strategic stability during the Cold War by preserving the logic of mutual assured destruction. The US withdrawal from the ABM Treaty in 2001 removed the only bilateral legal constraint on missile defence development that overlapped with ASAT capabilities, a move that China and Russia regard as having fundamentally destabilized the space arms control environment and that directly prompted their renewed push for the PPWT.

4. **Normative Frameworks**

Beyond these treaty-based instruments, several normative and soft-law frameworks are relevant. The UN Charter provisions on the prohibition of the use or threat of force (Article 2(4)) and the right of individual and collective self-defence (Article 51) apply to activities in outer space by virtue of Article III of the OST, which incorporates general international law. This means the use of ASAT weapons against another state's satellites could constitute an unlawful use of force under Article 2(4), though the application of principles of proportionality and necessity in this context remains contested. The Registration Convention of 1975 requires states to register objects launched into space with the UN Secretary-General, providing a baseline of transparency, though its disclosure requirements are insufficiently detailed for verification purposes in an arms control context.

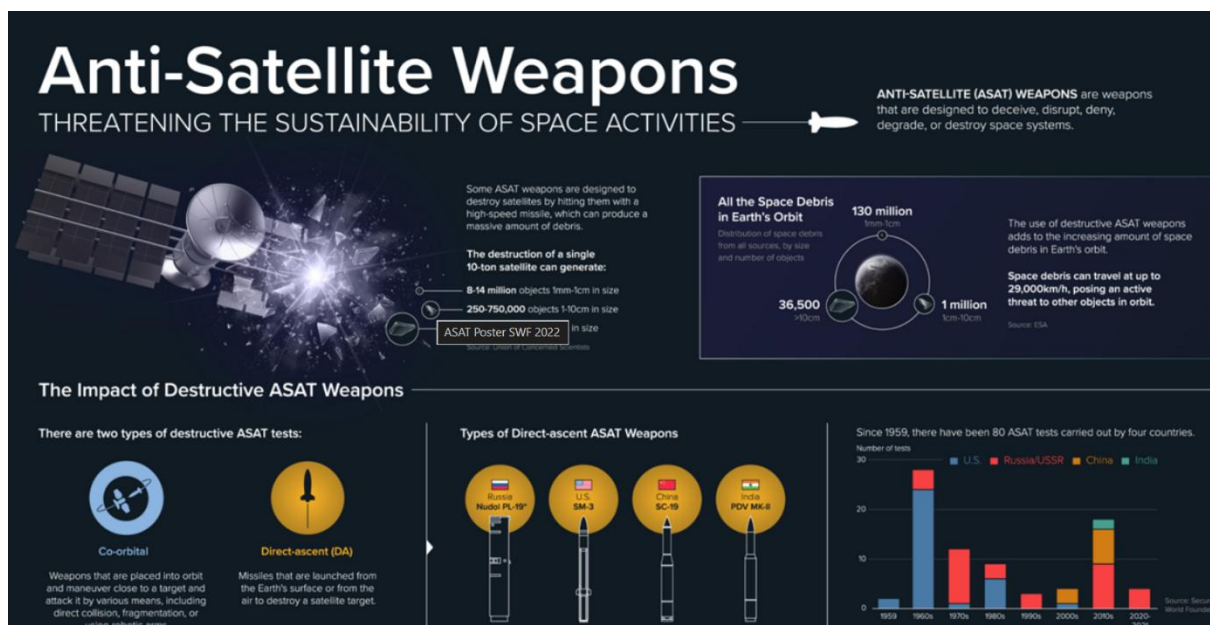
The UN Group of Governmental Experts (GGE) on Confidence Building Measures in Outer Space produced a consensus report in 2013 that articulated voluntary transparency and confidence-building measures, representing the most significant

multilateral agreement on responsible space behaviour in decades. The Long-Term Sustainability of Outer Space Activities (LTS) Guidelines, adopted by COPUOS in 2019, constitute the most significant international agreement on space governance in recent years; they are voluntary in nature but become legally binding as states incorporate them into national legislation. The draft PPWT (2008, revised 2014), while never adopted, remains the frontrunner among comprehensive treaty proposals given the notable lack of alternatives, though it is beset by the definitional, verification, and structural problems described throughout this guide.

Anti-Satellite Weapons

The proliferation of Anti-Satellite (ASAT) weapons, specifically direct-ascent (DA-ASAT) missiles, represents the most immediately destructive form of space weaponization. Launched from terrestrial platforms or aircraft, these missiles use hit-to-kill kinetic interceptors that rely on extreme impact velocities, rather than traditional explosives, to completely obliterate target satellites.

The paramount consequence of these kinetic strikes is the instantaneous creation of vast clouds of hypervelocity space debris that spread across multiple orbital altitudes. Because objects in low Earth orbit travel at immense speeds, even coin-sized fragments possess lethal energy capable of destroying other commercial, military, or crewed spacecraft. Ultimately, this accumulating debris risks triggering the "Kessler Syndrome," a self-sustaining cascade of collisions that could render critical orbital regimes entirely impenetrable and unusable for generations.



Offensive Counter-Space Capabilities

To avoid the disastrous orbital debris caused by traditional kinetic interceptors, global powers are increasingly fielding non-kinetic counter-space capabilities. These advanced technologies offer precise strategic effects without the environmental fallout, but they create complex regulatory challenges for the PAROS agenda. This spectrum of weapons includes stealthy co-orbital systems that manoeuvre near targets to use localized explosives, robotic arms, or chemical sprayers. It also features directed energy weapons, such as ground-based lasers and high-power microwaves, designed to temporarily blind optical sensors or permanently fry internal circuitry. Additionally, electronic warfare targets critical electromagnetic links through jamming, which drowns out legitimate signals, or spoofing, which injects deceptive data into navigation systems.

However, cyber warfare remains the most pervasive and accessible asymmetric threat, requiring no aerospace infrastructure to exploit software vulnerabilities in ground stations, modems, or satellite payloads. The devastating reality of this domain was illustrated on February 24, 2022, when Russian intelligence deployed "Acid Rain" malware against the Viasat satellite broadband network just hours before invading Ukraine. Rather than targeting the satellite in orbit, the cyberattack permanently wiped the memory of ground-based consumer modems to neutralize Ukrainian military command-and-control communications at

a highly vulnerable juncture.

2026 Global Assessment

	US	Russia	China	India	Aus.	France	Germany	Iran	Israel	Japan	N. Korea	S. Korea	UK
LEO Co-Orbital	None	Significant	None	Some	Some	None	Some	Some	Some	Some	Some	Some	Some
MEO/GEO Co-Orbital	None	None	None	Some	Some	None	Some	Some	Some	Some	Some	Some	Some
LEO Direct-Ascent	Significant	Significant	Significant	None	Some	Some	Some	Some	Some	Some	Some	Some	Some
MEO/GEO Direct-Ascent	?	?	None	Some	Some	Some	Some	Some	Some	Some	Some	Some	Some
Directed Energy	Significant	Significant	None	Some	Some	None	Some	Some	Some	Some	Some	Some	Some
Electronic Warfare	Significant	Significant	Significant	None	None	None	Some	Significant	Significant	None	Significant	Some	Some
Space Situational Awareness	Significant	Significant	Significant	None	None	None	None	None	None	None	None	None	None

Legend: None Some Significant Uncertain ?

Crucially for the PAROS agenda, this attack demonstrated severe transnational spill-over, underscoring the interconnected fragility of dual-use space networks. Because Viasat serves both military and civilian users, the operation unintentionally

disconnected tens of thousands of European broadband customers and severed remote connections to nearly 6,000 wind turbines in Central Europe. The Viasat incident proves that space weaponization is already an active reality in the cyber domain. It highlights the urgent need to regulate cyber and electronic warfare, as targeting dual-use satellite networks inevitably inflict disproportionate and unintended damage upon civilian infrastructure far removed from the battlefield.

Dual-Use Space Technologies

The regulation of outer space is complicated most acutely not by technologies that are unambiguously offensive, but by those that are not. Dual-use space technologies are systems and capabilities developed for legitimate civilian or scientific purposes that may simultaneously serve offensive military functions, these represent the most legally and diplomatically intractable dimension of the PAROS agenda. Unlike kinetic ASAT weapons, which carry an inherent offensive character, dual-use technologies resist clean categorisation, making them extraordinarily difficult to regulate without simultaneously constraining peaceful space activity.

The most consequential category is Rendezvous and Proximity Operations (RPO). The ability of one satellite to approach, inspect, or physically interact with another is essential for on-orbit servicing, debris removal, and satellite life-extension missions, all priorities endorsed by COPUOS and consistent with long-term orbital sustainability goals. Yet the same manoeuvring capability that enables a servicing satellite to dock with a disabled asset can be adapted to disable, reposition, or destroy an adversary's spacecraft. Nations including the United States, Russia, and China have each demonstrated advanced RPO capabilities under civilian or commercial justifications, with no internationally agreed mechanism to distinguish benign from hostile intent.

Space Situational Awareness (SSA) systems present an analogous dilemma. Ground-based and orbital sensors that track debris fields and monitor orbital congestion are foundational to safe space operations and are actively encouraged under UN guidelines. However, the same sensor infrastructure that maps debris can characterise adversary satellites with sufficient precision to enable targeting. Similarly, directed energy systems developed for debris

mitigation or communications, ground-based lasers in particular can be reconfigured to dazzle or permanently blind optical sensors on enemy satellites.

On-orbit inspection satellites, increasingly deployed by major spacefaring states under the rubric of space domain awareness, further exemplify the dual-use problem. These platforms are formally characterised as passive observation tools, yet their proximity maneuvering, imaging resolution, and operational profiles are functionally indistinguishable from co-orbital ASAT systems. The 1967 Outer Space Treaty prohibits the placement of weapons of mass destruction in orbit but contains no provision addressing these conventional-capability platforms.

For DISEC, the dual-use problem creates a fundamental regulatory challenge. The committee cannot prohibit technologies that underpin civilian space operations, debris management, and scientific research, all activities it is institutionally mandated to protect. What it can do is deliberate on transparency mechanisms, mandatory notification regimes for proximity operations, behavioural norms around SSA data sharing, and definitions that distinguish servicing missions from hostile interference. The absence of agreed definitions remains the first and most significant obstacle. Until the international community can establish what dual-use activity looks like in practice, regulation will remain a diplomatic aspiration rather than an operational reality.

Major Stakeholders

The space security landscape is defined by a small number of technologically advanced states whose strategic decisions disproportionately shape the trajectory of the PAROS agenda, alongside a growing coalition of emerging spacefaring nations and developing states whose interests are increasingly at stake. Understanding each stakeholder's position requires examining not merely their stated diplomatic posture, but their underlying strategic interests, technological capabilities, and the constraints that limit their flexibility at the negotiating

United States of America

The world's most capable spacefaring nation and most strategically dependent on satellite infrastructure. Washington opposes legally binding treaty obligations, citing verification infeasibility and structural gaps in the PPWT. It leads the voluntary norms coalition and kinetic ASAT testing moratorium, drawing leverage from its dominance over commercial space infrastructure and space situational awareness data. Growing allied pressure for more structured multilateral commitments remains its principal diplomatic constraint.

Russian Federation

Russia co-authored the PPWT and advocates for legally binding space weapons prohibitions, yet its 2021 Kosmos-1408 ASAT test exposed a critical gap between stated commitments and operational behaviour. Moscow views US missile defence and space-based sensor infrastructure as direct threats to its nuclear deterrent. Its leverage derives from its permanent Security Council seat and its sustained ability to block consensus at the Conference on Disarmament.

People's Republic of China

China co-sponsors the PPWT and advocates for a legally binding treaty at the CD against the voluntary norms approach. Its 2007 Fengyun-1C test and subsequent co-orbital developments

signal a comprehensive counter-space programme targeting US space dominance. Beijing resists transparency measures exposing its military space capabilities while simultaneously seeking international legitimacy for its expanding civilian and commercial space programmes.

Republic of India

A demonstrated ASAT-capable state pursuing deliberate strategic ambiguity. India supports PAROS objectives at the UNGA while asserting its sovereign right to develop capabilities commensurate with its security environment, driven by the asymmetric capability gap with China. As a Non-Aligned Movement member with cross-bloc partnerships, India holds meaningful bridge-building potential on this agenda that remains largely unutilised.

European Union and Allied Spacefaring States

The EU, United Kingdom, Japan, Canada, and Australia form the most cohesive bloc supporting structured multilateral engagement short of legally binding obligations. They endorse the ASAT testing moratorium and advocate for agreed behavioural norms. France holds a distinct position as the only EU member with an explicit space defence doctrine. The bloc's influence is constrained by its strategic dependence on US space capabilities.

Emerging Spacefaring Nations and the Developing World

South Korea, Israel, the UAE, and Brazil support international norms but resist frameworks entrenching existing technological advantages. For the G77 and Non-Aligned Movement, orbital slot preservation, spectrum access, and long-term sustainability are existential concerns. Despite lacking independent counter-space capabilities, this bloc holds substantial numerical influence within DISEC's one-state-one-vote structure and can decisively shape any resolution's normative direction.

Case Study: Russia's Kosmos-1408 Test

On 15 November 2021, the Russian Federation conducted a destructive direct-ascent anti-satellite missile test against Kosmos-1408, a defunct Soviet-era satellite in low Earth orbit. The test reportedly used Russia's Nudol anti-satellite system and physically destroyed the satellite, creating a large debris field. Unlike non-kinetic counter-space operations, which may disrupt or degrade a satellite temporarily, this was a kinetic strike that permanently fragmented the target.

The intercept occurred at an altitude of approximately 480 kilometres, generating more than 1,500 pieces of trackable debris and many smaller fragments that could not be reliably monitored. These fragments remain dangerous because even small pieces of debris can damage satellites and spacecraft at orbital velocities. The most immediate risk was to the International Space Station, where astronauts and cosmonauts had to take emergency precautions by sheltering inside docked spacecraft. This showed that an ASAT test against one state's own satellite can still endanger personnel and assets belonging to multiple countries.

The Kosmos-1408 incident demonstrates the indiscriminate nature of orbital debris. Once created, debris does not distinguish between military, civilian, commercial, or scientific satellites. A single destructive ASAT test can therefore threaten communications, Earth observation, weather monitoring, navigation systems, and human spaceflight. This transforms ASAT testing from a national security issue into a collective international security concern.

The incident also exposed a contradiction in Russia's diplomatic position. Russia has long supported the PPWT, a proposed treaty seeking to prevent the placement of weapons in outer space and the threat or use of force against space objects. However, the Kosmos-1408 test weakened Russia's credibility by showing that a state may publicly advocate for space arms

control while still conducting destructive counter-space operations. This contradiction is central to the PAROS debate.

From a legal perspective, the test highlights the weakness of existing space law. The Outer Space Treaty of 1967 bans nuclear weapons and other weapons of mass destruction in orbit, but it does not clearly prohibit conventional Earth-launched ASAT missiles. As a result, destructive ASAT tests may be condemned as irresponsible while still remaining in a legal grey area.

For DISEC, the Kosmos-1408 case study shows why any meaningful PAROS framework must address not only weapons placed in outer space, but also Earth-based systems capable of destroying space objects.

Questions A Resolution Must Answer (QARMA)

All resolutions emerging from this session must remain grounded in the mandate of DISEC, the existing legal framework governing outer space, and the political realities of the current multilateral environment. The QARMA framework ensures that every proposed measure answers not only what must be done, but how, by whom, and under what authority it can be implemented. Delegates are expected to anchor their responses in international law, institutional feasibility, and the procedural jurisdiction of the United Nations.

Definitions and Scope

- How should DISEC operationally define anti-satellite weapons, offensive counter-space capabilities, and dual-use technologies for the purposes of a regulatory framework?
- Where does legitimate military space activity end and weaponization begin, and how can this boundary be codified without rendering existing military satellite operations unlawful?
- Should any regulatory framework distinguish between kinetic and non-kinetic counter-space capabilities, and if so, on what legal and technical basis?

Verification and Attribution

- What verification mechanisms are technically feasible given the dual-use nature of most advanced space technologies, and which international body should administer them?
- How can the international community attribute responsibility for non-kinetic counter-space operations; particularly cyber and electronic warfare, where technical attribution remains contested and legally ambiguous?

- In the absence of a permanent international monitoring body, what interim transparency measures can DISEC recommend that are politically acceptable to major spacefaring states?

Legally Binding Instruments vs Voluntary Norms

- Should DISEC recommend the negotiation of a legally binding treaty on space weapons, or advocate for an incremental voluntary norms' framework as a more immediately achievable objective?
- How can the committee bridge the fundamental diplomatic divide between states advocating for the PPWT and those supporting the voluntary norms approach without producing a resolution that satisfies neither bloc?

Debris and Environmental Consequences

- What immediate measures can DISEC recommend to disincentivize destructive kinetic ASAT testing, and how should non-compliance with such measures be addressed within the committee's advisory capacity?
- Should a moratorium on kinetic ASAT testing be recommended as a universal obligation, and how can the committee ensure that existing debris-generating states bear proportionate responsibility for remediation?

Role of Non-Spacefaring and Developing States

- How can DISEC ensure that any regulatory framework preserves equitable access to outer space for developing states and does not entrench the technological advantages of existing space powers?
- What mechanisms can guarantee that smaller states contribute meaningfully to space governance without possessing independent verification or counter-space capabilities?

Institutional Reform and DISEC's Role

- How can DISEC strengthen the multilateral space security architecture given the sustained deadlock at the Conference on Disarmament and the failure of the OEWG to produce a consensus final report?
- What procedural or institutional mechanisms should DISEC recommend to ensure that future space security negotiations are inclusive, technically informed, and insulated from great power obstruction?

Delegates must remember that DISEC cannot create enforcement bodies with powers comparable to the Security Council, authorize military action, or impose binding obligations on Member States. Its strength lies in its ability to build consensus, codify restraint, and establish the normative foundations upon which future legally binding instruments may eventually rest.

Key Acronyms

Acronym	Full Form
ABM	Anti-Ballistic Missile Treaty
ASAT	Anti-Satellite Weapon
CD	Conference on Disarmament
COPUOS	Committee on the Peaceful Uses of Outer Space
DA-ASAT	Direct-Ascent Anti-Satellite Weapon
DEW	Directed Energy Weapon
DISEC	Disarmament and International Security Committee
EW	Electronic Warfare
GGE	Group of Governmental Experts
GNSS	Global Navigation Satellite System
KE-ASAT	Kinetic Energy Anti-Satellite Weapon
LTS	Long-Term Sustainability Guidelines
OEWG	Open-Ended Working Group
OST	Outer Space Treaty
PAROS	Prevention of an Arms Race in Outer Space
PPWT	Treaty on the Prevention of the Placement of Weapons in Outer Space

Acronym	Full Form
PTBT	Partial Test Ban Treaty
RPO	Rendezvous and Proximity Operations
SSA	Space Situational Awareness
TEL	Transporter-Erector-Launcher
UNGA	United Nations General Assembly
UNSC	United Nations Security Council